Political Culture

POLS 2311: Government of the United States

Agenda

- Define *political culture* and identify the core elements of American political culture
- Compare American political culture to that of other democracies
- Identify the sources of American political culture
- Evaluate conflicts within American political culture and their effect on trust and tolerance

WHAT DO YOU THINK OF WHEN YOU THINK OF THE *POLITICAL* CULTURE OF THE UNITED STATES?

WHAT IS POLITICAL CULTURE?

Political Culture

- **Political culture**: *a patterned and sustained way of thinking about how political and economic life ought to be carried out*
- Shapes what citizens expect from government and what they consider *legitimate*
- Distinct from *political ideology*, *public opinion* and *institutions*
  - Political culture is the underlying normative environment within which they operate
- Differences among nations

A Shared Culture



Enigma/Alamy Stock Photo

The US is a Creedal Nation

- **Creedal nation**: national identity defined by shared commitment to a set of political ideals, not by ethnicity, religion, or common ancestry
- What binds Americans together isn't a common ethnicity or ancestry but agreement on a shared set of political values
  - liberty, equality, democracy, civic duty, and individual responsibility

ELEMENTS OF THE AMERICAN POLITICAL SYSTEM

Five Defining Elements

- Liberty
- Equality
- Democracy
- Civic Duty
- Individual Responsibility

Civic Duty and Civic Competence

- **Civic Duty**: a belief that one has an obligation to participate in civic and political affairs
- **Civic Competence**: a belief that one can affect government policies

LIBERAL DEMOCRACY

Liberal Democracy: A Definition

- **Liberal democracy**: a form of government that combines democratic self-rule with constitutional limits protecting individual rights against the state, and against majorities
- It blends two distinct commitments
  - **Democracy** — political authority derives from the consent of the governed, exercised through free and fair elections
  - **Liberalism** — individuals hold claims to liberty that government, and even democratic majorities, cannot legitimately override

Institutions of Liberal Democracy

- Elections contested between distinct political parties
- Separation of powers across branches of government
- Rule of law and an independent judiciary
- Protection of individual rights and civil liberties
- Pluralism — a free press, free association, alternative sources of information
- A **market economy** — private property and competitive markets as the default system for allocating goods

When Democracy and Liberalism Conflict

- Liberal democracy's two halves can pull apart
- **Tyranny of the majority**: democratic majorities may use their power to oppress minorities
- **Political ignorance**: limited voter information can produce systematic errors in collective choice
- **Democratic self-destruction**: elections can bring illiberal leaders to power who then dismantle the institutions that elected them

Liberal Democracy and Mediating Institutions

- Liberal democracy depends on **mediating institutions** between the individual and the state: family, religious congregations, civic associations, interest groups, parties, media
- These institutions produce civic trust, political information, and habits of self-governance
- Their erosion — declining social capital, shrinking civic life — threatens liberal democracy itself

ECONOMIC CULTURE AND CAPITALISM

The American Economic System

- Americans favor *equality of opportunity* over *economic equality*
- Support of the free-enterprise system
- Tolerate economic inequality
- Value self-reliance
- Will help those “truly in need”

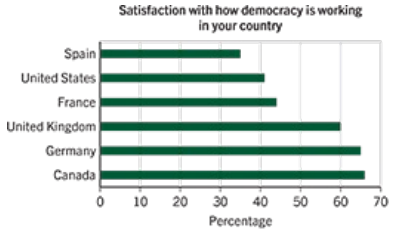
Capitalism: A Definition

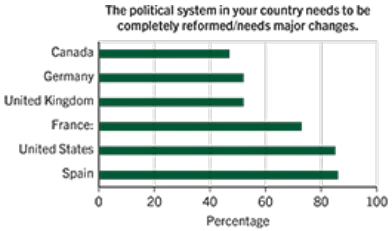
- **Capitalism**: an economic system based on private ownership of property and the means of production, competitive markets, and voluntary exchange for profit
- Government's role is limited primarily to enforcing contracts and protecting property rights
- The "free enterprise system" Americans favor is capitalism in practice

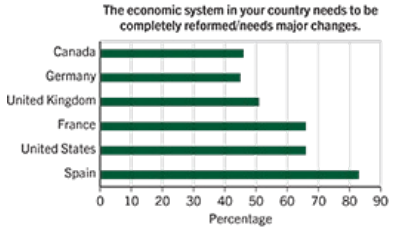
HOW THE UNITED STATES COMPARES

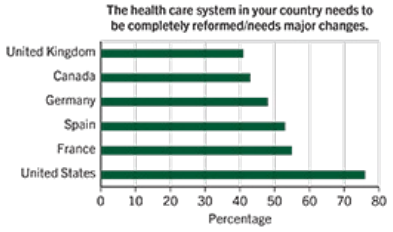
Comparative Political Participation

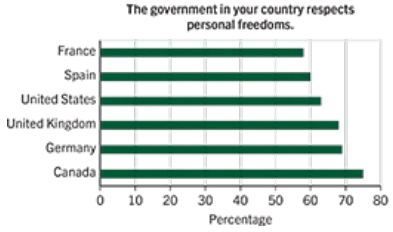
- The U.S. lags behind Austria, the Netherlands, Germany, and the United Kingdom in *voter turnout*
- But Americans are as active — or substantially more active — in: campaigning, attending political meetings, community involvement, and contacting government officials

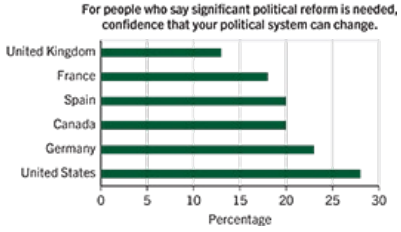

Satisfaction with how democracy is working in your country
Spain
United States
France
United Kingdom
Germany
Canada
0 10 20 30 40 50 60 70
Percentage

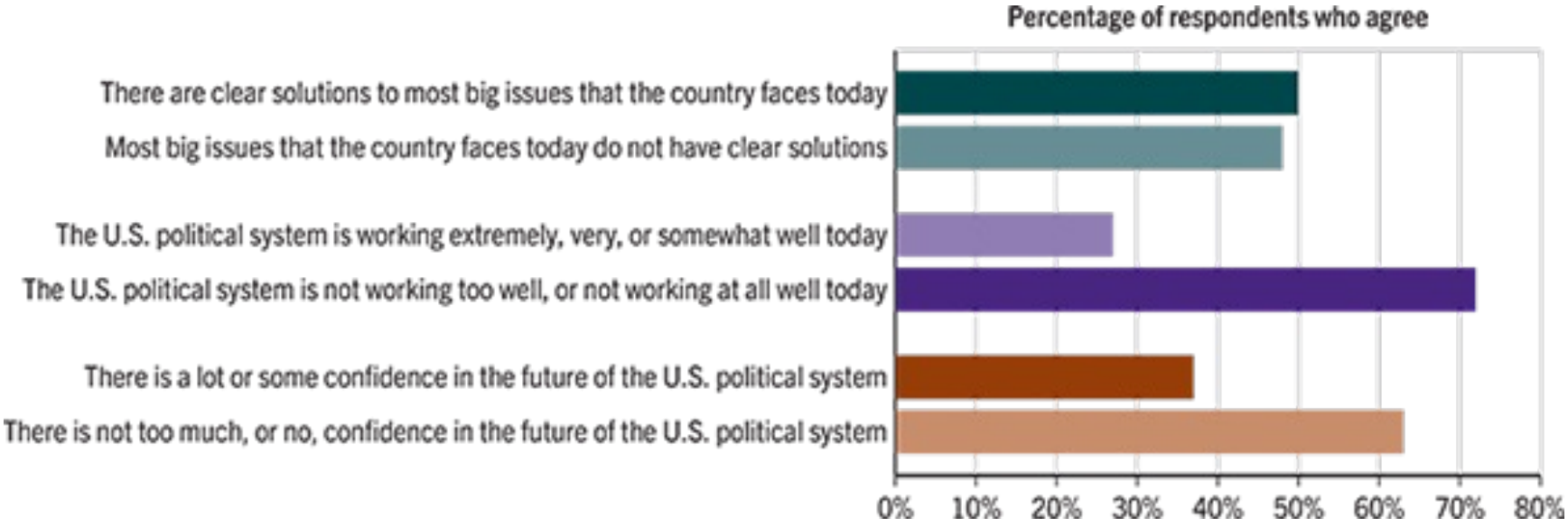

The political system in your country needs to be completely reformed/needs major changes.
Canada
Germany
United Kingdom
France:
United States
Spain
0 20 40 60 80 100
Percentage


The economic system in your country needs to be completely reformed/needs major changes.
Canada
Germany
United Kingdom
France
United States
Spain
0 10 20 30 40 50 60 70 80 90
Percentage


The health care system in your country needs to be completely reformed/needs major changes.
United Kingdom
Canada
Germany
Spain
France
United States
0 10 20 30 40 50 60 70 80
Percentage


The government in your country respects personal freedoms.
France
Spain
United States
United Kingdom
Germany
Canada
0 10 20 30 40 50 60 70 80
Percentage

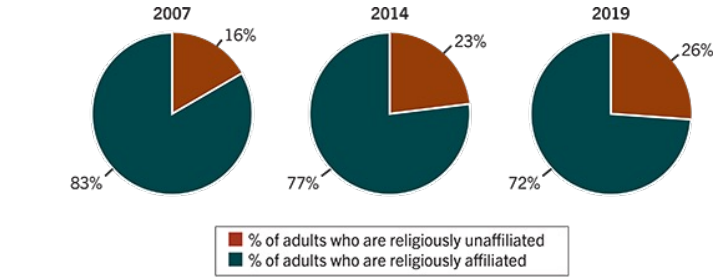

For people who say significant political reform is needed, confidence that your political system can change.
United Kingdom
France
Spain
Canada
Germany
United States
0 5 10 15 20 25 30
Percentage

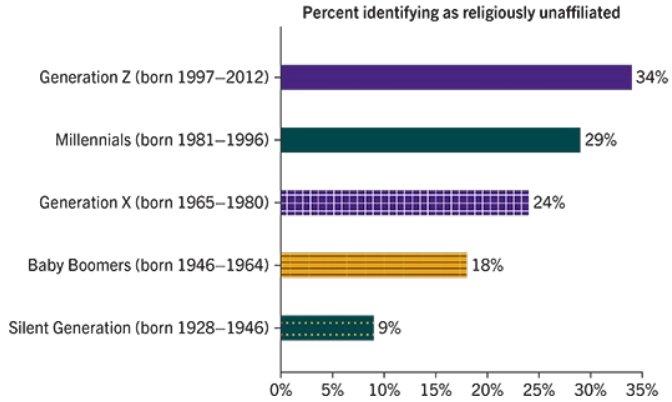

Percentage of respondents who agree
There are clear solutions to most big issues that the country faces today
Most big issues that the country faces today do not have clear solutions
The U.S. political system is working extremely, very, or somewhat well today
The U.S. political system is not working too well, or not working at all well today
There is a lot or some confidence in the future of the U.S. political system
There is not too much, or no, confidence in the future of the U.S. political system
0%
10%
20%
30%
40%
50%
60%
70%
80%

THE CIVIC ROLE OF RELIGION

Religion and Political Culture

- America has long been among the most religious countries in the world
- Both liberals and conservatives have used the pulpit to promote political change
- Fewer Americans are identifying with a religion
  - ~1/3 of Gen Z are religiously unaffiliated, vs. ~1/4 of Gen X and less than 1/5 of Baby Boomers


2007
16%
83%
2014
23%
77%
2019
26%
72%
% of adults who are religiously unaffiliated
% of adults who are religiously affiliated


Percent identifying as religiously unaffiliated
Generation Z (born 1997–2012)
34%
Millennials (born 1981–1996)
29%
Generation X (born 1965–1980)
24%
Baby Boomers (born 1946–1964)
18%
Silent Generation (born 1928–1946)
9%
0%
5%
10%
15%
20%
25%
30%
35%

SOURCES OF POLITICAL CULTURE

Sources

- Shared history
- Dominant religious beliefs
- Family
- What else shapes American political culture?

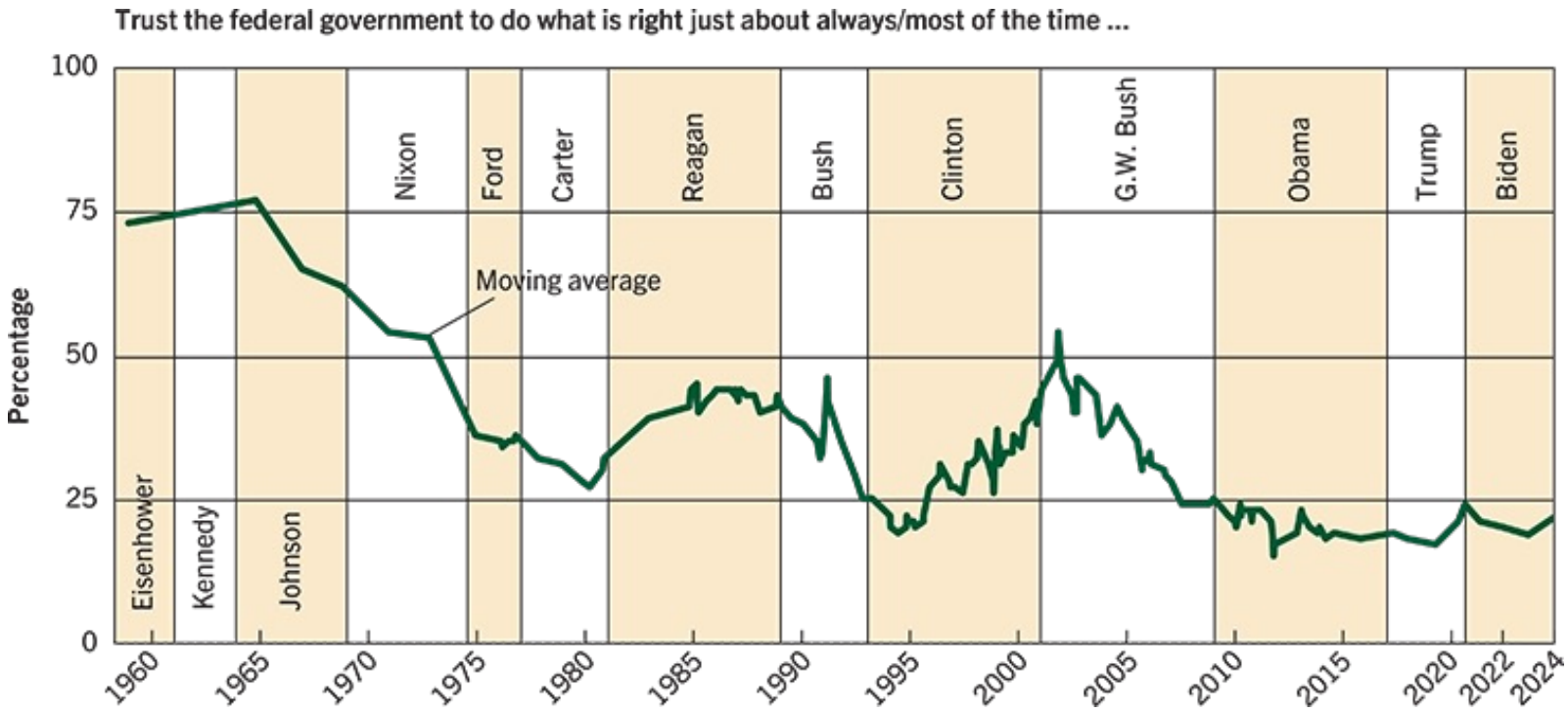
Class Consciousness and the Culture War

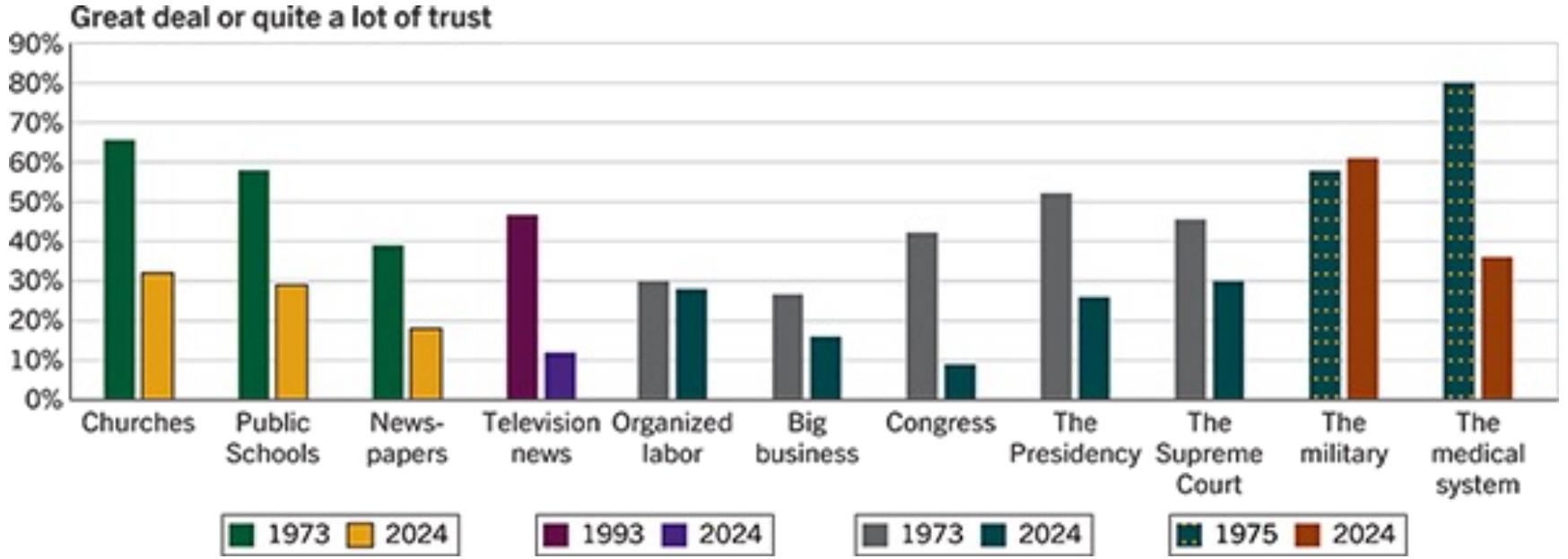
- **Class Consciousness**: a belief that one is a member of an economic group whose interests are opposed to people in other such groups
- **Orthodox**: a belief that morality and religion ought to be of decisive importance
- **Progressive**: a belief that personal freedom and solving social problems are more important than religion
- *Culture war issues include*: abortion rights, LGBTQ+ rights, gun control, religious freedom vs. secularism, and education

TRUST, TOLERANCE, AND CIVIL SOCIETY

Mistrust of Government

- Trust in government has remained consistently below 30% since 2008
- But: survey respondents are often talking about *politicians*, not the system of government itself


Trust the federal government to do what is right just about always/most of the time ...
Percentage
100
75
50
25
0
Moving average
Eisenhower
Kennedy
Johnson
Nixon
Ford
Carter
Reagan
Bush
Clinton
G.W. Bush
Obama
Trump
Biden
1960
1965
1970
1975
1980
1985
1990
1995
2000
2005
2010
2015
2020
2022
2024


Great deal or quite a lot of trust
90%
80%
70%
60%
50%
40%
30%
20%
10%
0%
Churches
Public Schools
News-papers
Television news
Organized labor
Big business
Congress
The Presidency
The Supreme Court
The military
The medical system
1973
2024
1993
2024
1973
2024
1975
2024

- Confidence has declined across most institutions — churches, public schools, newspapers, television news, Congress, the presidency, the Supreme Court
- The military is the sole major exception, rising over the same period

Civil Society and Social Capital

- **Civil Society**: voluntary action that makes cooperation easier
- Americans are more likely than people in other democracies to join voluntary groups
- The more **social capital** a community has, the greater the level of trust among its members

Civic Virtue: A Founding-Era Warning

- Benjamin Franklin: *“Only a virtuous people are capable of freedom. As nations become corrupt and vicious, they have more need of masters”* (1787)
- Tocqueville: voluntary associations train citizens in cooperation and public spirit without relying on the state
- Tocqueville’s warning of *soft despotism*: in a prosperous democracy, people may willingly trade freedom for comfort

Political Tolerance

- Democratic politics depends on reasonable tolerance of the opinions and actions of others
- **Paradox of tolerance**: are there views that should *not* be tolerated in a free society?


THE PARADOX OF TOLERANCE
BY PHILOSOPHER KARL POPPER*
SHOULD A TOLERANT SOCIETY TOLERATE INTOLERANCE?
YOU WANT MORE TOLERANCE? RESPECT MY IDEAS!
THE ANSWER IS NO.
IT'S A PARADOX, BUT UNLIMITED TOLERANCE CAN LEAD TO THE EXTINCTION OF TOLERANCE.
WHEN WE EXTEND TOLERANCE TO THOSE WHO ARE OPENLY INTOLERANT...
LETS GIVE THEM A CHANCE!
...THE TOLERANT ONES END UP BEING DESTROYED. AND TOLERANCE WITH THEM.
ANY MOVEMENT THAT PREACHES INTOLERANCE AND PERSECUTION MUST BE OUTSIDE OF THE LAW.
AS PARADOXICAL AS IT MAY SEEM, DEFENDING TOLERANCE...
...REQUIRES TO NOT TOLERATE THE INTOLERANT.
*Source: The Open Society and Its Enemies. Karl R. Popper
PICTOLINE COM

Tolerance and the Courts

- Courts are sufficiently insulated from public opinion that they can act against majority sentiments and enforce constitutional protections
- Connects to Madison and Tocqueville's concern over *tyranny of the majority*: the danger that a democratic majority uses its power to oppress a minority